

Killing Time

No matter how busy you are, there are always some moments when you just need to “kill some time.”

You may scroll through social media, play a game on your phone, or read the news.

When you have a few minutes to kill, you can use it as a period of practice.

Instead of telling yourself that these habits are bad or wrong, you can use them as a focus for your mindfulness, thus making them more restorative and restful.

You can use this exercise to take a break from your day at work or at home, using your few free minutes to arrive in the present moment.

This exercise will focus specifically on the use of smartphones, as this is a common way many of us check out during the day.

When you have a few minutes to spare in which you would normally kill time, notice the habitual urge to waste time.

(This doesn't mean you label the habit wrong or bad; it's just about observing.)

As you begin participating in your normal method of killing time, bring some mindfulness to the act.

If you take your phone out, pay attention to your state of mind as you do so.

Can you be fully present as you begin scrolling through social media, playing a game, or reading a news story?

Use the sense of sight as the object of your awareness.

Watch what you are doing as you do it.

Pay attention to the picture as a whole, and the individual parts of what you are seeing.

Notice colors, shapes, movement, and anything that grabs your attention.

As you click the screen or interact with your phone, be mindful of the interaction between the body and the device.

Continue to “kill time” mindfully, attending to the actions with a gentle awareness.

Don’t judge yourself for taking a break.

Be proud you are using your break to take care of yourself and cultivate mindfulness.